

SOME CASES GET CLOSED.
THIS ONE STAYED.

FILES — THEY — BURIED

THE CASE THAT STAYED

— BOOK ONE —

DR. S. KHANNA
CONSULTANT PSYCHIATRIST



Not a
Manual.
A Mind.

ANOTHER
SUICIDE
PUZZLES
POLICE

Victim was under
therapy. No foul
play suspected.

CASE FILE: 001

STATUS:

CLOSED

NOT SOLVED.



He listened.
They followed.

EVIDENCE

Control.
Obedience.
Order.
Release.
Completion.
The mind.
will choose
silence.

A KABIR VERMA INVESTIGATION

VARUN CHAUBEY

FILES THEY BURIED: THE CASE THAT STAYED



The file is closed.

That is what the record says.

Every signature is there.

Every report has been filed.

Every page has been stamped.

According to the department...

the case is over.

I wish I believed that.

My name is Kabir Verma. At the time, I was a police

investigator—I believed that if something was written down, it existed—new to major cases, careful with procedure, still honestly.

convinced that paperwork had meaning.

I was wrong.

This was the first case they trusted me with.
The one that taught me how easily silence can be filed as resolution.

Officially, it ended years ago.

But it never left.

...

It started like any other day.

I was sitting in my office, finishing paperwork from a previous case, when my senior called me in. He handed me a file and

informed me that a suicide had been reported on the outskirts of the city. I was being assigned to assist in the investigation.

At the time, it sounded routine.

It wasn't.

When I reached the crime scene, the trees blocked most of the morning light.

Birds still sang overhead.

It felt wrong.

Places where people died weren't supposed to feel that peaceful.

Yellow police tape stretched between the trees while a handful of officers searched the area in silence.

Another officer was already beside the body, studying the scene with a notebook in his hand. As I approached, my senior gestured toward him.

"Kabir, this is Vikram Chauhan."

Vikram looked up, closed his notebook, and offered me a firm handshake.

"First major case?" he asked.

"Yeah."

He gave a faint nod.

"Mine too."

He slipped the notebook back into his pocket.

"Let's hope it stays routine."

Neither of us knew then how long that case would stay with us. The victim was a middle-aged man dressed in formal clothing. A knife rested loosely in his hand; the blade covered in blood that belonged only to him.

His throat had been cut deeply.

Everything about the scene suggested suicide.

The silence in the room felt almost deliberate.

The knife was sent for forensic examination while Vikram and I searched the area for anything unusual.

At first glance, nothing stood out.

Then I noticed one of the victim's fingernails was missing.

Not broken. Missing.

Probably caught on something.

It seemed insignificant. Small enough to ignore.

I wrote it down anyway.

After several hours of investigation, the conclusion remained the same. No evidence suggested the presence of another person at the scene. The forensic report confirmed that the fingerprints on the knife belonged only to the victim. Officially, it was suicide.

The case was closed within days.

I was assigned to complete the paperwork, but something about the case stayed with me. Not the violence. I had seen violence before.

It was the arrangement of everything.

The clean clothes.
The calm expression.
The precision.

It didn't feel impulsive.

It felt prepared.

Still, without evidence, instinct meant nothing.

So I filed the report.

Cause of Death:

Suicide.

Investigation Status:

Closed.

I stared at the final line longer than I should have.

Nothing in the report was false.

Yet something about it felt incomplete.

Eventually...

I signed it.

...

A few days later, another death was reported in the same area.

Vikram and I arrived at the scene before sunrise. The moment
I stepped into the room, I stopped walking.

Another body.

Another formal outfit.

Another knife resting in the victim's hand.

Another throat cut deep enough to leave no doubt.

And again, the body was unusually clean.

The resemblance to the previous case was impossible to ignore.

This time, I examined the hands first.

One fingernail missing.

The same finger.

I looked at Vikram. He had noticed it too.

"You thinking what I'm thinking?" he asked quietly.

"That this isn't coincidence?" I replied.

For the first time since joining the investigation, the silence between us felt uneasy.

But once again, the forensic reports pointed toward suicide. No foreign fingerprints. No signs of restraint. No evidence of forced involvement.

According to procedure, the case was closed.

According to instinct, it had just begun.

One missing fingernail could be ignored.

Two could not.

...

I couldn't let it go.

When I brought up the similarities, most people dismissed them as stress-related suicides. Two unfortunate incidents connected only by circumstance.

But patterns do not appear accidentally.

Especially not careful ones.

I discussed it with Vikram later that evening. He listened quietly while I explained the similarities between the two deaths.

“The clothes,” I said. “The condition of the bodies. The fingernails. None of it feels random.”

Vikram leaned back in his chair, thinking for a moment.

“If we can’t reopen it officially,” he said, “then we investigate unofficially.”

It was a reckless idea.

I agreed immediately.

...

Over the next few days, Vikram collected information about the victims while I visited their families and workplaces, searching for anything the official investigation might have missed.

The family of the first victim described him as stable and hardworking. According to them, he had no reason to take his own life.

His colleagues said the same thing.

Quiet. Professional. Normal.

I heard that word repeatedly during the investigation.

Normal.

The second victim's ex-wife painted a different picture.

Their marriage had ended only a few months earlier.

Money had become a constant source of arguments.

He'd started sleeping less.

Working longer hours.

Smiling less.

But according to everyone who knew him...

he never spoke about giving up.

He still made plans.

He still showed up to work.

He still called his daughter every weekend.

Nothing suggested he was preparing to die

Days passed without progress. Every lead ended in silence.

One evening, exhausted and frustrated, I sat alone in my office reviewing the files again when my phone rang.

Unknown number.

When I answered, a woman's voice spoke calmly from the other side.

"If you really want to understand those deaths," she said, "meet me at Royal Café tomorrow. Five o'clock."

Before I could respond, the call disconnected.

I stared at the phone for several seconds.

Then I wrote down the address.

...

The next evening, I reached the café ten minutes early.

A woman was already sitting near the window with two untouched cups of coffee on the table. When she saw me, she gestured for me to sit.

She introduced herself as the best friend of the first victim.

At first, she seemed nervous. Careful with every word. But slowly, the conversation changed the direction of the entire investigation.

According to her, the victim had been under severe emotional stress for months.

“No one knew,” she told me quietly. “He didn’t want his family worrying about him.”

For the first time since the case began, the image people had created around the victim started to crack.

Everyone had described him as fine.

Functional would have been a more accurate word.

There’s a difference.

She explained that he had recently started visiting a therapist Dr. Ahuja.

I asked for the name immediately.

. . .

Dr. Ahuja’s clinic was located across the city in a quiet commercial building. Calm colours. Soft music. The kind of place designed to make people feel safe.

Dr. Ahuja himself appeared calm and professional.

When I mentioned the first victim, he nodded immediately.

“Yes,” he said. “He was one of my patients.”

“Did he ever mention harming himself?”

“No,” the therapist replied. “In fact, he seemed to be improving.”

His answers were controlled. Measured. Genuine.

I kept questioning him, but nothing directly connected him to the deaths. According to records, he had been out of town during the first victim’s death, and the victim’s next appointment had already been scheduled for the following week. Legally, there was nothing suspicious.

Before leaving, I asked him one final question.

“If you were out of town,” I said, “who handled your patients?”

For the first time during the conversation, he hesitated slightly.

“Only emergency consultations,” he replied. “Some patients were temporarily redirected.”

“Redirected to who?”

He opened a drawer and searched through a file for several seconds before handing me a visiting card.

Another therapist.

Smaller clinic. Private practice.

I looked at the card for longer than I should have.

Something about it felt important.

...

When I stepped out of the clinic, evening had already settled across the city.

I stood beside my car, staring at the visiting card in my hand while traffic moved around me.

Two suicides.

Two identical crime scenes.

Two missing fingernails.

And now a second therapist no one had mentioned before.

For the first time since the investigation began, the case no longer felt confusing.

It felt hidden.

I called Vikram immediately.

“I think we’ve been looking at the wrong person,” I told him.

There was silence on the other side for a moment.

Then Vikram spoke quietly.

“Good,” he said. “That means we’re finally getting closer.”

At the time, I believed him.

I didn’t know then that this was the moment the case truly began.

The next morning, Vikram and I planned to visit the second therapist whose name appeared on the referral card. We never got the chance.

At 6:17 AM, my phone rang.

Another death.

By the time we reached the scene, local officers had already secured the area. The crowd outside was larger than before. News of two identical suicides had already begun spreading through the city, and a third would be impossible to dismiss.

I pushed through the police tape and stepped inside.

The victim was a woman in her mid-twenties. Formal clothing.

Clean appearance. A knife in her hand. A deep wound across her throat.

For a moment, nobody spoke.

The room felt familiar.

Too familiar.

I crouched beside the body and examined her hands. One fingernail was missing. The same finger. The same clean removal.

I looked up at Vikram.

Neither of us needed to say anything.

Three victims. Three identical scenes. Three impossible coincidences.

This was no longer a suspicion.

One missing fingernail could be ignored.

Two couldn't.

I couldn't explain why.

I just knew I wasn't looking at coincidence anymore.

The forensic reports arrived later that evening. Once again, there were no signs of forced entry, no evidence of struggle, and no foreign fingerprints.

Officially, it was another suicide.

Unofficially, everyone in the department knew something was wrong.

The following morning, Vikram and I were called to ACP Devendra Sinha's office. Neither of us spoke much on the way there. The third death had changed everything. For the first time, I wasn't trying to prove a theory.

I was trying to stop whatever came next.

ACP Devendra Sinha sat behind his desk reviewing files when we entered. He didn't ask us to sit immediately. Instead, he finished reading the page in front of him before closing the file and removing his glasses. Only then did he look up.

"Sit."

We obeyed.

The room remained silent for several seconds before he slid three crime-scene photographs across the desk. The victims stared back at us from the glossy prints. Side by side, the similarities were impossible to ignore. "Tell me what you see."

For the next fifteen minutes, Vikram and I explained everything. The identical crime scenes. The missing fingernails. The

victims' hidden struggles. The therapy sessions. The anonymous call. The referral to a therapist no one had mentioned before.

When we finished, ACP Sinha remained silent.

His expression never changed.

Finally, he removed his glasses and placed them carefully on the desk.

"You know what concerns me?" he asked.

Neither of us answered.

"None of this is in your official reports."

Vikram and I exchanged a glance.

He was right.

Everything that mattered had been discovered outside procedure.

ACP Sinha leaned back in his chair.

"When I joined the force," he said quietly, "I was exactly like you."

The room fell silent.

"I believed patterns mattered more than paperwork. I believed instinct could solve cases before reports ever could."

He paused.

"Sometimes it can."

It was the first honest thing any senior officer had said to me since the investigation began.

Most trusted procedure.

Most ignored instinct.

Devendra Sinha understood both.

Without looking away from us, he continued.

"The difference is that I learned something you haven't."

"What?" I asked.

"The truth isn't enough."

I didn't understand what he meant at the time.

Years later, I would.

He opened another file and looked directly at us.

"Officially, this investigation is now yours."

For a moment, I felt relief.

Then he continued.

"You have one week."

The relief vanished immediately.

"One week?" Vikram repeated.

"Seven days," ACP Sinha replied. "Find evidence. Find a witness. Find anything I can place in front of people who only believe what they can stamp, sign, and archive."

He closed the file.

"If you fail, the investigation goes back to being what it is now."

Nobody spoke.

We all knew what he meant.

The case would disappear.

Filed away.

Forgotten.

Buried.

Even then, I hated that word.

His eyes shifted toward the visiting card I had placed on the desk earlier.

"The second therapist."

I nodded.

"Yes, sir."

"Then stop wasting time."

For the first time since entering the office, there was something sharp in his voice.

"Go meet him."

As Vikram and I stood to leave, ACP Sinha spoke once more.

"Verma."

I stopped and turned.

"If your instincts are right..."

He glanced briefly at the photographs on his desk.

"...don't wait for a fourth body to prove it."

Outside the office, neither Vikram nor I spoke for several moments. The city moved around us—cars, people, noise, life.

Somewhere among all of it was a man connected to three deaths.

Maybe more.

For the first time since this investigation began, we had a direction.

The second therapist.

And somehow, I had a feeling he had been expecting us for a long time.

We went straight to the second therapist's clinic.

The moment we entered, something about the place felt different from Dr. Ahuja's clinic. The lighting was dull, the waiting area almost completely silent, and there wasn't a single patient in sight. We approached the reception desk and asked to meet the doctor.

"I'm sorry, there are no more appointments for today," the receptionist said.

"We're not here for an appointment," I replied, showing her my identification. "Police. We need to speak with the doctor regarding an ongoing investigation."

Her expression changed immediately.

She picked up the phone, spoke quietly for a few moments, then placed it back on the desk.

"He'll see you."

Vikram and I exchanged a glance before entering the cabin.

A small nameplate beside the door read:

DR.	SAMEER	KHANNA
CONSULTANT PSYCHOLOGIST		

Dr. Khanna was sitting behind his desk. Behind him hung several framed certificates and photographs. One was an old graduation photograph, though at the time I barely gave it a second glance.

He sat there calm and composed, almost as if two police officers appearing unannounced at his clinic was nothing unusual.

“Officers,” he said pleasantly. “Please, sit.”

We took our seats.

Vikram wasted no time. He placed a photograph of the first victim on the desk.

“Do you recognize this man?”

Dr. Khanna looked at the photograph.

There was barely a pause.

“Yes. I remember him.”

I watched his face carefully.

“He was referred to me by Dr. Ahuja for an emergency consultation while Dr. Ahuja was out of town. He was dealing with severe stress, mostly because of his workload.”

“What happened during the consultation?” I asked.

“We talked. I helped him work through some of what he was experiencing, and then he went home.”

He looked at the photograph again.

“What happened afterward, I cannot tell you.”

There was something strange about the way he spoke.

Nothing he said was unreasonable. Nothing sounded rehearsed enough to call it a lie. Yet the longer I listened to him, the easier it became to believe him.

Almost too easy.

For a moment, I found myself wondering why I had suspected him in the first place.

That thought bothered me.

Vikram placed the photograph of the second victim beside the first.

“And him?”

Dr. Khanna studied it.

“No.”

“You’re certain?”

“Quite.”

Then came the third photograph.

Again, he shook his head.

“I’ve never treated either of them.”

He didn't hesitate when we asked to verify his statement. His patient records were brought in, and we went through them ourselves.

The first victim was there.

The other two weren't.

We had finally found someone connected to one of the deaths.

The problem was that we had absolutely nothing connecting him to the others.

No appointments.

No records.

No evidence.

We left the clinic with more questions than we'd entered with.

...

Back at the office, I decided to start again with the third victim.

She was a woman in her twenties and a psychology student at a local college.

I went through everything we had collected about her—academic records, recent activities, contacts, photographs.

Nothing immediately stood out.

Then I read the name of her college again.

Something about the name of her college felt familiar.

I stared at it for a few seconds.

I had seen that name before.

But where?

I leaned back in my chair, trying to retrace the past few days in my head—the families, the café, Dr. Ahuja's clinic...

Then I remembered.

Dr. Sameer's Cabin.

There had been a framed photograph hanging on the wall behind his desk. An old graduation photograph. I hadn't paid much attention to it at the time, but the name of the college had been printed beneath it.
The same college.

I immediately searched through the therapist's professional information.

There it was.

He was an alumnus.

That alone meant nothing. Thousands of students had passed through those halls, and graduating from the same college as one of the victims hardly connected him to her death.

Still, something bothered me.

I opened the third victim's college records and began going through her recent activities.

Seminars.

Workshops.

Department events.

Then I found one.

A guest lecture on stress, mental health, and coping with academic pressure.

I looked at the date.

The day before her death.

Then I looked at the list of invited speakers.

His name was there.

I read it twice.

Then a third time.

I stood so quickly that my chair rolled backward.

“Vikram.”

He looked up from his desk.

I turned the screen toward him and pointed at the event notice.

“The third victim’s college.”

“What about it?”

“I saw this name in his clinic.”

Vikram looked at me.

“Our therapist studied there.”

I pointed to the guest list.

“And yesterday I thought that was just a coincidence.”

His eyes moved down to the date.

His expression changed.

“He was there the day before she died.”

I nodded.

We had asked the therapist if he had treated her.

He said no.

His records confirmed it.

But we had never asked whether he had met her.

For the first time, we had connected him to a second victim.

Not through an appointment.

Not through a patient record.

Through opportunity.

And suddenly, one question mattered more than anything else.

What happened at that college the day before she died? Vikram read through the event description.

The topic was stress, mental health, and coping with academic pressure.

That alone proved nothing. Dr. Sameer Khanna was a therapist. Speaking about mental health at a college was hardly suspicious.

But coincidences had already cost us three bodies.

"We need to visit the college," I said.

...

We reached the campus later that afternoon.

The event had been organized by the Department of

Psychology, and after speaking with the administration, we were directed to one of the professors who had helped coordinate it.

I showed her a photograph of the third victim.

Her expression changed immediately.

"Yes, she was there."

"You're certain?"

"She helped us organize the event. Student registrations, coordinating with the guests, managing the auditorium—she was involved in almost everything."

I looked at Vikram.

That meant she hadn't simply attended Dr. Khanna's lecture.

She had been working around him for hours.

"Did you see them speak to each other?"

The professor thought for a moment.

"During the event? Probably. She was coordinating with all the guests."

"After the event?"

This time, she hesitated.

"Actually... yes."

That caught my attention.

"What did you see?"

"Most people had already started leaving. I remember seeing the two of them talking near the auditorium."

"Were they alone?"

"I think so."

"Could you hear what they were discussing?"

She shook her head.

"No."

"How long were they together?"

"I couldn't tell you. I left shortly afterward."

"Did anyone else see them?"

"The official photographer was covering the closing ceremony. If anyone captured it, it would be him."

I exchanged a glance with Vikram.

"Do you still have the photographs from the event?"

"They should be in the mediaarchive."

...

A staff member led us to a small office where photographs from previous college events were stored.

The event folder contained hundreds of pictures.

Students on stage.

Faculty members posing with guests.

Award ceremonies.

Group photographs.

Most of them were useless.

Vikram and I went through them one by one.

Five minutes passed.

Then ten.

Just as I was beginning to think the professor had remembered wrong...

I stopped.

"Wait."

I went back one photograph.

Dr. Sameer Khanna wasn't the subject of the picture. He was barely noticeable in the background.

But he was there.

Standing near the end of a corridor outside the auditorium.

And standing across from him was the third victim.

They were alone.

I enlarged the photograph.

It became grainier, but there was no mistaking either of them.

Vikram leaned toward the screen.

"So, he knew her."

"Maybe."

"He told us he didn't."

I kept staring at the photograph.

"No."

"What do you mean?"

I replayed our conversation with Dr. Khanna in my head.

His exact words echoed back to me.

"I've never treated either of them."

He hadn't lied.

Not once had we asked whether he had met her.

Not once had we asked whether they had spoken.

There is a difference between telling a lie...

...and allowing someone to believe the wrong thing.

For the first time, I understood what made Dr. Sameer Khanna dangerous.

He didn't need to hide the truth.

He just needed us to misunderstand it.

I closed the photograph and stood up.

"We're going back."

"To Dr. Khanna?" Vikram asked.

I nodded.

"This time..."

I looked at the photograph one last time.

"...I'm not going there to find answers."

Vikram frowned.

"Then why?"

"To find out what question he wanted us to ask."

...

The drive back to Dr. Sameer Khanna's clinic was unusually quiet.

Neither of us spoke.

My eyes remained fixed on the road, but my mind replayed every word from our first meeting.

"I've never treated either of them."

Not a lie.

Not the truth either.

Just enough to make us stop asking.

A man like that didn't answer questions.

He controlled them.

And if I wanted to prove he was a killer, I had to stop thinking like a police officer.

I had to start thinking like him.

My phone vibrated.

ACP Devendra Sinha.

I answered immediately.

"Sir."

"Any progress?"

"We found a connection between Dr. Sameer Khanna and the third victim."

"What kind of connection?"

"He spoke at her college the day before she died."

There was silence on the other end.

"Do you have evidence that links him to the murder?"

"No, sir."

"Did anyone witness him threatening her?"

"No."

"Any forensic evidence?"

"No."

"A photograph proves they met, Kabir."

"It doesn't prove murder."

I clenched the steering wheel.

"Yes, sir."

His voice remained calm.

"How many days has it been?"

I already knew the answer.

"Four."

"That leaves you three."

"Three days, Kabir. If you can't prove it by then, I'll have no choice but to hand the case over."

Three days.

Seventy-two hours.

After that, the case would be reassigned, and every unofficial lead I'd been following would disappear into someone else's file.

"I understand, sir."

"I know you believe he's involved, Kabir."

His tone softened slightly.

"But belief doesn't convict people."

"Evidence does."

The call ended.

Neither Vikram nor I spoke for several minutes.

Finally, he broke the silence.

"He's right."

"He usually is."

"What if we're wrong?"

I looked out of the windshield.

"What if Dr. Khanna is exactly what he appears to be?"

I didn't answer immediately.

Instead, I remembered something he'd said before we left his office.

"People usually hear the answer they want."

At the time, I'd dismissed it as another one of those philosophical line therapists liked to use.

. . .

Now I wondered whether it had been meant for me all along.

Now...

it felt personal.

"He isn't."

"You sound awfully sure."

"I've interviewed murderers before."

Vikram looked at me.

"They lie."

I tightened my grip on the steering wheel.

"He doesn't."

. . .

By the time we reached the clinic, the evening rush had begun.

The waiting area was full.

A young receptionist looked up as we entered.

"Oh... Officers."

"Is Dr. Khanna available?"

"I'm afraid he's with a patient."

"We'll wait."

She glanced toward the cabin before replying.

"The session shouldn't take much longer."

Vikram and I sat across from the cabin door.

For the next twenty minutes, nothing happened.

Some walked in with anxious faces.

Others left looking lighter.

Some didn't.

No raised voices.

No arguments.

No signs of panic.

Just another ordinary psychiatric clinic.

Exactly the kind of place where nobody expected evil to exist.

The cabin door finally opened.

A young man couldn't have been older than twenty-three.

His eyes were swollen.

His sleeves were rolled down despite the summer heat.

He kept rubbing his thumb against his wrist as though trying to erase something invisible.

Dr. Sameer Khanna walked him to the door.

"You've done well today," he said gently.

The young man gave a faint nod before leaving the clinic.

For a moment, our eyes met.

Then he disappeared outside.

Dr. Khanna turned toward us.

He looked at us for only a moment before smiling.

Not surprised.

Not concerned.

Almost... pleased.

"Inspector Verma."

He glanced at Vikram.

"Officer Chauhan."

"I had a feeling you'd be back."

He turned toward the receptionist.

"Please hold my next appointment for ten minutes."

"Yes, Doctor."

He opened the cabin door and stepped aside.

"Come in."

There wasn't the slightest trace of surprise on his face.

No nervousness.

No irritation.

If anything...

he looked as though he'd been expecting us all afternoon.

Vikram and I entered the cabin.

Dr. Khanna closed the door behind us before returning to his chair.

"Would either of you like some coffee?" he asked.

"No," I replied.

He smiled faintly.

"I didn't think so."

For a moment, nobody spoke.

The silence stretched just long enough to become uncomfortable.

Dr. Khanna seemed perfectly content to let it.

I reached into my file and placed the photograph from the college on his desk.

It slid to a stop in front of him.

He looked down at it.

His expression didn't change.

"Oh," he said calmly.

"That photograph."

"You remember it."

"I remember the event."

He picked up the photograph and studied it for a few seconds before placing it back on the desk.

"One of the students must have taken it."

"She isn't just any student," I said.

"You know who she is."

"I do now."

"You knew her before she died."

Dr. Khanna folded his hands on the desk.

"I met hundreds of students that day, Inspector Verma."

"Some asked questions during the session."

"Others spoke to me afterward."

"Meeting someone and remembering them after seeing their photograph are two very different things."

His answer was careful.

Too careful.

"You never mentioned that."

"You never asked."

I leaned forward.

"We asked whether you knew the victim."

"No."

"You asked whether she had been my patient."

He held my gaze.

"And she wasn't."

I replayed our first conversation in my head.

Every word.

Every answer.

Damn him.

He was right.

Again.

Vikram broke the silence.

"So, you admit you spoke to her."

"Of course."

Dr. Khanna answered without hesitation.

"She approached me after the lecture."

"What did she want?"

"The same thing many students wanted."

"And what was that?"

He gave a small, almost sympathetic smile.

"Someone to listen."

"And did you?"

"For a few minutes."

"What did you talk about?"

"I don't remember the exact conversation."

"You expect us to believe that?"

"I speak to dozens of people every week, Inspector."

He leaned back slightly.

"Do you remember every stranger you've spoken to in the past month?"

I didn't answer.

Because I couldn't.

He noticed.

"I thought not."

Another point to him.

The room fell silent again.

Dr. Khanna looked from me to Vikram.

Then, for the first time since we'd entered, he changed the subject completely.

"May I ask you something, Inspector?"

I frowned.

"I'll be asking the questions."

"Humour me."

His voice remained calm.

"It won't take long."

I said nothing.

He smiled.

"I'll take that as a yes."

He studied me for a moment.

Not my face.

My posture.

My hands.

The way I was sitting.

Then he spoke.

"How many hours have you slept this week?"

I blinked.

"What?"

"You heard me."

"Answer the question."

"I'm not here to discuss myself."

"No."

He nodded.

"You're here because you believe I'm responsible for three deaths."

He tilted his head slightly.

"And yet..."

"...you're exhausted."

Neither Vikram nor I spoke.

"You've been running on caffeine."

He glanced at the paper cup in my hand.

"Your right hand hasn't stopped moving since you walked in."

Only then did I realize my thumb was tapping against the edge of the cup.

I stopped immediately.

Dr. Khanna smiled.

"You, see?"

"I notice people."

"It's part of my profession."

His eyes shifted toward Vikram.

"And you..."

Vikram looked up.

"What about me?"

Dr. Khanna studied him for a second longer than he had studied me.

"You say very little."

"But when you do..."

"...Inspector Verma listens."

Vikram let out a small laugh.

"I wouldn't read too much into that."

"I'm not."

Dr. Khanna replied.

"I'm simply making an observation."

Then he looked back at me.

"Tell me, Inspector..."

"If I truly were the man, you believe I am..."

"Why would I still be sitting here?"

I didn't answer.

Neither did he.

For several seconds, the room was silent.

Then Dr. Khanna stood up.

"I believe our ten minutes are over."

He walked toward the door and opened it.

It wasn't a request.

It was a dismissal.

"You can leave now, Inspector."

His tone remained polite.

Professional.

As though we had simply discussed the weather.

I stood, but before leaving, I turned back.

"Three people are dead."

Dr. Khanna nodded.

"I know."

"And you're the last person all three of them trusted."

For the first time since we'd entered his office, his smile disappeared.

"They trusted me because they believed I could help them."

"They died anyway."

A shadow crossed his face.

"Yes."

"That bothers me every day."

His answer caught me off guard.

There was no defensiveness.

No anger.

Only... disappointment.

For a moment, I almost believed him.

Almost.

I stepped toward the door.

"One last question."

He looked up.

"If you had known they were going to die..."

"...could you have stopped them?"

Dr. Khanna held my gaze for several seconds.

Finally, he answered.

"I ask myself that every night."

I searched his face for even the smallest crack.

Nothing.

If it was an act...

it was flawless.

We left without another word.

...

The evening air felt colder than before.

Vikram closed the car door and let out a long breath.

"Well?"

I started the engine.

"Well, what?"

"What do you think?"

I pulled away from the curb.

"I think he planned that entire conversation."

Vikram frowned.

"You asked the questions."

"No."

I shook my head.

"He decided which ones mattered."

"He answered everything."

"Exactly."

I glanced in the rearview mirror.

The clinic was already disappearing behind us.

"He never denied speaking to the third victim."

"He admitted it."

"He never denied meeting the first victim."

"He admitted that too."

"He never lied."

Vikram looked confused.

"Then why are you still convinced?"

"Because innocent people answer questions."

I tightened my grip on the steering wheel.

"Guilty people answer the questions that help them."

Silence filled the car.

Then Vikram said quietly,

"So, what now?"

I looked out at the traffic ahead.

"We stop asking Dr. Sameer Khanna questions."

Vikram turned toward me.

"We ask everyone else."

The next morning, Vikram dropped a stack of files onto my desk.

"Everything we could find on Dr. Sameer Khanna." I

opened the first file.

Medical Council registration.

Valid.

Degrees.

Verified.

Employment history.

Clean.

No complaints.

No disciplinary action.

No malpractice cases.

Nothing.

I flipped to the next file.

Bank statements.

Regular salary.

Taxes paid.

No unexplained transactions.

No gambling.

No debts.

Nothing.

The next file.

Phone records.

No suspicious calls.

No contact with any of the three victims outside official clinic hours.

Again...

Nothing.

By lunchtime, my desk was buried beneath paperwork.

By evening...

I had learned everything about Dr. Sameer Khanna.

Except how he was killing people.

...

"What about his family?" I asked.

Vikram looked up from his laptop.

"Parents passed away years ago."

"Married?"

"No."

"Relationship?"

"None that we could find."

"Friends?"

"A few colleagues."

"Anyone willing to speak against him?"

Vikram shook his head.

"They all said the same thing."

"What?"

"He's one of the kindest people we've ever worked with."

I leaned back in my chair.

Every answer pushed him further away from being a murderer.

And somehow...

that only made me more certain.

...

The following evening, we visited his apartment.

A modest two-bedroom flat.

Nothing luxurious.

Nothing neglected.

His neighbor, an elderly woman in her seventies, welcomed us inside.

"You've come about Dr. Khanna?"

"Yes."

She smiled.

"Such a nice young man."

"How long have you known him?"

"Almost six years."

"What kind of neighbor is he?"

"The kind everyone wishes they had."

She laughed softly.

"He brings my groceries upstairs."

"Checks on me whenever I fall sick."

"Even fixed my ceiling fan once."

I exchanged a glance with Vikram.

She noticed.

"You don't think he did something terrible..."

"...do you?"

I didn't answer.

Instead, I asked,

"Have you ever heard arguments from his apartment?"

"No."

"Visitors late at night?"

"No."

"Anything unusual?"

She thought for a moment.

Then smiled again.

"Only one thing."

My pulse quickened.

"He reads."

"Books?"

"So many books."

"I've never seen anyone buy that many."

For a second...

I thought we'd finally found something.

Then I realized...

reading books wasn't exactly a crime.

...

Over the next two days...

we interviewed everyone.

Receptionists.

Former interns.

College professors.

Neighbors.

Former patients.

Every single one described the same man.

Patient.

Kind.

Gentle.

Professional.

If there was another version of Dr. Sameer Khanna...

he had hidden it from the entire world.

...

By the end of the sixth day, I was staring at the investigation board in complete silence.

Three victims.

Three suicides.

One therapist.

Dozens of interviews.

Hundreds of pages of reports.

Zero evidence.

Vikram walked into the room carrying two cups of coffee.

He handed me one.

"I think we're done."

I didn't look away from the board.

"No."

"We've checked everything."

"No."

"We've got nothing."

I kept staring at the victims' photographs.

Then...

something bothered me.

Not about Dr. Khanna.

About the clinic.

I closed my eyes.

Trying to remember.

The waiting room.

The receptionist.

The patients.

The second visit.

A young man walked out.

Swollen eyes.

Exhausted face.

Dr. Khanna had walked him to the door.

Then...

a voice echoed somewhere in the back of my mind.

"Mr. Arjun Mehta..."

My eyes opened.

The coffee slipped from my hand and crashed onto the floor.

Vikram jumped.

"Kabir?"

I ignored him.

I grabbed my notebook from the shelf.

Every interview.

Every address.

Every observation.

I flipped through the pages until I found it.

Reception Log - Dr. Sameer Khanna's Clinic

4:40 PM - Mr. Arjun Mehta

I stared at the name.

Then at the three photographs pinned to the board.

The first victim.

The second.

The third.

Every one of them had been alive the last time someone saw them leaving Dr. Khanna's clinic.

My heart began to race.

"What if..."

Vikram frowned.

"What?"

I looked at him.

"What if we're looking for the next victim..."

"...instead of the last one?"

The room fell silent.

For the first time in six days...

we weren't chasing a dead person.

We were chasing someone who was still alive.

"Kabir..."

Vikram looked at me.

"You think Dr. Khanna has already chosen his next victim."

"I don't think."

I closed the notebook.

"I know."

The image of the clinic waiting room came rushing back.

Patients had come and gone without a second glance.

But Arjun had been different.

He hadn't looked at anyone.

His eyes had stayed fixed on the floor, as if he were carrying a weight too heavy to share.

Even after the session ended, Dr. Khanna hadn't simply called for the next patient. He had walked Arjun all the way to the door.

"You've done well today," he'd said.

At the time, I'd dismissed it as a therapist reassuring a struggling patient.

Now it sounded different.

Personal.

Final.

And Arjun hadn't looked relieved.

He'd looked... resigned.

Suddenly, the memory of the missing fingernails, the identical deaths, and that quiet farewell fell into place.

My pulse quickened.

"He's next."

Within minutes, we were back in the jeep.

Vikram was already searching government records.

"Arjun Mehta."

Several names appeared.

"Which one?"

I remembered the young man's face.

"Twenty-two or twenty-three."

Vikram filtered the results.

Three remained.

We spent the next three hours visiting every address.

The first Arjun Mehta was forty-seven years old.

The second was a school teacher.

The third...

The apartment was locked.

I knocked again.

No answer.

An elderly landlord stepped out from the neighboring flat.

"Looking for Arjun?"

"Yes."

"He left this morning."

"Where?"

The old man shrugged.

"Didn't say."

"When will he be back?"

"I don't know."

My stomach sank.

...

Kabir immediately calls ACP Sinha.

"Sir."

"What is it?"

"I think I know who the next victim is."

"You think?"

"I need surveillance."

"You have no evidence."

"I know."

"I need officers."

Silence.

Then ACP Sinha sighed.

"You have until six."

That was all.

No promises.

No backup.

No warrant.

Only time.

Only time.

. . .

Kabir checks

phone records

bank transactions

college

workplace

Nothing.

Then...

his debit card is used.

A pharmacy.

Kabir rushes there.

Too late.

The cashier remembers him.

"Quiet boy."

"Bought sleeping pills?"

"No."

"Bandages."

That seems meaningless.

Until Kabir remembers...

Every victim removed one fingernail.

Bandages.

The hairs on his neck stand up.

...

Kabir races back.

"We're running out of time."

...

Vikram suddenly notices something.

"Wait."

"What?"

"The therapist never called him."

Kabir stops.

"...Go on."

"He told us his patients contact him."

Kabir freezes.

"If Arjun wants to meet him..."

"...he'll make the call."

Kabir immediately requests the telecom team to watch Arjun's number.

Hours pass.

Nothing.

Then...

The phone rings.

Unknown number.

Arjun answers.

The call lasts only 18 seconds.

Kabir immediately requests the tower location.

The signal originates...

Near an old riverside park.

Kabir and Vikram arrive quietly.

Kabir stepped forward.

"Arjun!"

The young man turned.

His face showed surprise.

"Inspector?"

Before Kabir could say another word, another voice interrupted.

"Arjun!"

A man in his early twenties jogged toward them carrying two cups of coffee.

"Sorry, bhai. The café took forever."

He stopped after noticing the police.

"Everything alright?"

Arjun looked confused.

"Yeah... he's my college friend."

Kabir stared at him.

"You called him here?"

Arjun nodded.

"He wanted to check on me."

Kabir looked around.

No Dr. Khanna.

No hidden meeting.

No trap.

Nothing.

Just two friends meeting after months.

Vikram sighed.

"We were wrong."

I didn't answer.

I looked at my watch.

5:12 PM.

Less than an hour remained before ACP Devendra Sinha would take the case away.

For six days...

I'd chased a ghost.

...

The drive back felt longer than any before it.

Neither of us spoke.

Finally Vikram broke the silence.

"Maybe we wanted him to be guilty."

I kept my eyes on the road.

"No."

"We've got nothing, Kabir."

"I know."

"We're out of time."

"I know."

He looked at me.

"So what now?"

I pulled the jeep to the side of the road.

"I'm not done."

The drive back to headquarters felt longer than any before.

Neither of us spoke.

Finally, Vikram broke the silence.

"Maybe we wanted him to be guilty."

I kept my eyes on the road.

"No."

"We've got nothing, Kabir."

"I know."

"We're out of time."

"I know."

He looked at me.

"So what now?"

I pulled the jeep over to the side of the road.

For a few seconds, neither of us said anything.

Then I handed him the case file.

"Take this back to headquarters."

Vikram frowned.

"What?"

"You heard me."

"What about you?"

I looked out toward the road where I'd last seen Arjun disappear.

"I'm going to follow him."

"On what basis?"

"I don't have one."

"Then ACP Sinha is going to tear you apart."

"Probably."

Vikram stared at me for a moment.

"You really think he's the next one."

"I don't know."

I took a slow breath.

"But if I'm wrong..."

"...I'll lose a case."

I looked at him.

"If I'm right..."

"...we lose another life."

Vikram sighed.

"You know this is unofficial."

"I know."

"If ACP asks where you are?"

"Tell him the truth."

"Which is?"

I opened the car door.

"That I refused to give up."

For a moment, Vikram looked as if he wanted to argue.

Instead, he simply nodded.

"Be careful."

"You too."

I closed the door.

The jeep pulled away toward headquarters.

I watched it disappear into the evening traffic.

Then I turned in the opposite direction.

For the first time since the investigation began...

I was completely alone.

I checked my watch.

5:18 PM.

Forty-two minutes.

That was all the time I had before ACP Devendra Sinha officially took the case away from me.

I pulled my cap lower and started walking.

Keeping just enough distance that Arjun would never know I was there.

Kabir followed Arjun from a distance.

He never looked back.

His steps were slow.

Aimless.

As if he wasn't walking toward a destination...

but away from his own life.

He crossed the main road and entered an old riverside park.

The place was deserted.

Only the sound of flowing water broke the silence.

Kabir kept enough distance to stay unnoticed.

Then...

Arjun stopped.

Someone emerged from the darkness.

Dr. Sameer Khanna.

Kabir's heartbeat quickened.

He reached for the recorder in his pocket and switched it on.

Neither of them shook hands.

Neither smiled.

They simply stood there.

As if this meeting had already happened a hundred times before.

Dr. Khanna spoke first.

"You came."

Arjun nodded weakly.

"I wasn't sure I would."

"You still aren't."

Silence.

Dr. Khanna didn't move closer.

He let the silence do the work.

Finally, Arjun spoke.

"I can't do this anymore."

"I know."

"I've tried."

"I know."

"They'll all be better without me."

Dr. Khanna didn't agree.

He didn't disagree.

Instead, he asked quietly,

"Do you still feel anything?"

Arjun stared at the ground.

"No."

Another long silence.

Then Dr. Khanna reached into his coat pocket.

Kabir instinctively tensed.

But it wasn't a knife.

It wasn't poison.

It was a small metal nail cutter.

He placed it on the bench between them.

Kabir frowned.

Dr. Khanna looked at Arjun.

"Do you remember what I told you?"

Arjun slowly nodded.

"The body always hesitates before the mind does."

Dr. Khanna gently pushed the nail cutter toward him.

"If you can remove it..."

"...then you've already made your decision."

Arjun's hands trembled.

He picked up the nail cutter.

His breathing became uneven.

Slowly...

he held his hand out.

The same finger.

The same fingernail.

Kabir's eyes widened.

This was it.

This was why every victim had been missing a fingernail.

It wasn't a signature left after death.

It was a test before it.

Arjun squeezed the cutter shut.

A cry of pain escaped his lips.

Blood trickled down his finger.

Dr. Khanna watched without emotion.

"How do you feel?"

Arjun looked at the blood.

"I..."

"...I don't know."

"Do you want to stop?"

Arjun closed his eyes.

"No."

Dr. Khanna nodded once.

"Then you're ready."

That was enough.

Kabir stepped out from behind the trees.

"Enough!"

Both men turned.

Arjun stumbled backward.

The nail cutter fell to the ground.

Dr. Khanna remained perfectly calm.

"I was wondering how long you'd watch."

Kabir marched toward him.

"What the hell are you doing?"

Dr. Khanna looked at Arjun.

"I never touched him."

Kabir grabbed him by the collar.

"You've manipulated him for weeks!"

"I asked questions."

"You made him do this!"

Dr. Khanna glanced at the bleeding finger.

"No."

"He chose to."

Kabir looked at Arjun.

"Is that true?"

Tears streamed down the young man's face.

"...Yes."

"I did it."

"No one forced me."

Kabir's grip tightened.

For a moment, he realized the nightmare he'd been chasing. Dr.

Khanna had engineered everything...

without giving a single direct instruction.

Kabir pulled out the handcuffs.

Dr. Khanna didn't resist.

He calmly held out his wrists.

As the cuffs clicked shut, he smiled.

"I was beginning to think..."

"...you wouldn't make it in time."

Kabir placed the case file on the table.

The interrogation room was silent.

Dr. Sameer Khanna sat across from him, his hands cuffed to the metal ring fixed to the table.

He looked... relaxed.

Almost relieved.

Kabir remained standing.

"You know why you're here."

"I assume you have a theory."

Kabir slid three photographs across the table.

The victims.

"They're dead."

Dr. Khanna looked at them for a few seconds.

Then nodded.

"They are."

"You knew every one of them."

"I did."

"You manipulated them."

"I spoke to them."

"You made them believe death was the answer."

Dr. Khanna looked up.

"No."

"I made them admit..."

"...they already believed it."

Kabir slammed both hands onto the table.

"Stop hiding behind words!"

"For six days I've been digging through their lives."

"I've met their families."

"I've watched parents bury their children."

"And you expect me to believe you're innocent?"

For the first time...

Dr. Khanna's expression changed.

Not fear.

Disappointment.

"I never said I was innocent."

The room fell silent.

...

Kabir sat down.

"If not innocent..."

"...then what are you?"

Dr. Khanna looked at the ceiling.

"A failure."

Kabir frowned.

"I became a psychologist because I believed everyone could be saved."

He smiled bitterly.

"I was wrong."

"Some people..."

"...stop living long before they stop breathing."

...

Kabir opened another file.

"The second victim."

"You never treated him."

"No."

"Then explain."

Dr. Khanna leaned back.

"He drove a cab."

Kabir waited.

"I was his passenger."

"He talked the entire journey."

"About his divorce."

"His daughter."

"His debts."

"His insomnia."

"I never asked."

"He volunteered everything."

Kabir remembered the ride history they had recovered.

One trip.

Thirty-two minutes.

Nothing unusual.

Until now.

"Three days later..."

Dr. Khanna continued.

"He booked an appointment."

"And after that?"

"I listened."

"You asked your questions."

"I did."

"And then he died."

"He chose to."

Kabir's jaw tightened.

...

"What about the fingernails? And why only the index finger?"

For the first time...

Dr. Khanna smiled.

"You noticed."

"It wasn't a signature."

"It was a question."

Kabir stared at him.

"A question?"

"When people say they don't feel anything anymore..."

"...they're usually lying."

"So I asked them to prove it."

Kabir felt a chill run down his spine.

"If removing a fingernail caused unbearable pain..."

"...there was still something inside them fighting to live." "And if it didn't?"

"They had already surrendered."

"And the index finger.

The finger people use to point.

At others.

At themselves.

At blame."

Kabir whispered,

"So that's how you decided..."

"...who couldn't be saved."

Dr. Khanna didn't answer.

He didn't have to.

...

Kabir slowly closed the file.

"You played God."

"I believed I could recognize hopelessness."

"And Arjun?"

Dr. Khanna looked toward the one-way mirror.

"He surprised me."

Kabir frowned.

"He hesitated."

"He cried."

"He still wanted someone to stop him."

A long pause.

"You arrived before I finished."

Kabir stared at him.

"So I saved him."

Dr. Khanna looked directly into Kabir's eyes.

"Yes."

Another silence filled the room.

Then Dr. Khanna spoke again.

"Congratulations, Inspector."

"You saved one."

. . .

Kabir stood.

The interrogation was over.

He walked to the door.

His hand was already on the handle.

Then...

Dr. Khanna spoke one last time.

"Inspector."

Kabir didn't turn around.

"You solved my case."

A faint smile crossed Dr. Khanna's face.

"But you still haven't solved yours."

Kabir slowly looked back.

Dr. Khanna wasn't looking at him anymore.

He was looking past him.

Through the glass.

At Vikram.

Dr. Khanna smiled.

Not at Kabir.

At Vikram.

And for the first time since his arrest...

Kabir felt something he hadn't felt throughout the entire investigation.

Unease.

Kabir stood outside the interrogation room.

Through the glass, Dr. Sameer Khanna sat exactly where he had left him.

Calm.

Almost peaceful.

ACP Devendra Sinha walked up beside him.

"So?"

Kabir exhaled slowly.

"He admitted enough."

"Enough for court?"

"I don't know."

Sinha folded his arms.

"But?"

"But enough for me."

For a moment, neither of them spoke.

Then Sinha asked,

"What's bothering you?"

Kabir kept his eyes on the room.

"He surrendered too easily."

. . .

Sinha looked through the glass.

"Maybe he knew he'd lost."

Kabir shook his head.

"No."

"A man like him always has another move."

. . .

Inside the room, Dr. Khanna looked up.

Almost as if he knew they were talking about him.

He smiled.

Not mocking.

Expecting.

Kabir frowned.

"I want one more conversation."

Sinha hesitated.

"You've already questioned him for three hours."

"One last time."

...

Kabir entered the room alone.

He didn't sit immediately.

Instead, he stood across the table.

"You've answered every question I asked."

Dr. Khanna smiled.

"You finally learned to ask the right ones."

Kabir ignored the remark.

"There's one I still don't understand."

"Oh?"

"You could've run."

"Yes."

"You could've denied everything."

"Probably."

"You could've destroyed your notes."

"I never kept any."

Kabir leaned forward.

"So why stay?"

For the first time...

Dr. Khanna laughed.

A quiet laugh.

Not because the question was funny.

Because he'd been waiting for it.

"I was wondering when you'd ask."

...

He leaned back in his chair.

"Tell me, Inspector."

"If a teacher finishes teaching..."

"...what does he do next?"

Kabir frowned.

"He leaves."

"Exactly."

Silence.

"I had already taught everyone I intended to."

Kabir's expression hardened.

"You mean your victims."

Dr. Khanna slowly shook his head.

"No."

"My victims are dead."

Kabir stared at him.

"Then who?"

A faint smile appeared on Dr. Khanna's face.

"I think..."

"...you'll find the answer yourself."

Kabir leaned forward.

"What does that mean?"

"It means some lessons aren't understood when they're taught."

"They're understood much later."

Kabir frowned.

"I don't have time for riddles."

Dr. Khanna chuckled softly.

"I know."

He stood as far as the handcuffs allowed.

"And that's exactly why you'll miss it."

Kabir slammed the file shut.

"This conversation is over."

Dr. Khanna didn't object.

As Kabir reached the door, Dr. Khanna spoke one final time.

"Inspector."

Kabir stopped but didn't turn around.

"You saved a life today."

A pause.

"You'll remember this conversation one day."

Kabir looked back.

"What is that supposed to mean?"

Dr. Khanna simply smiled.

"You'll decide that."

Kabir stared at him for a moment before opening the door.

...

Outside, Vikram was waiting.

He stood as Kabir walked out.

"Finished?"

Kabir nodded.

"Yeah."

"Did he confess?"

Kabir thought for a moment.

"Not in the way I wanted."

Vikram looked toward the interrogation room.

"So what now?"

Kabir glanced back at the closed steel door.

"Now the court decides."

Without another word, they walked down the corridor.

Behind them...

Dr. Sameer Khanna remained seated in the interrogation room.

His expression unreadable.

The newspapers called it The Riverside Suicide Case.

Some called Dr. Sameer Khanna a serial killer.

Others called him a misunderstood psychologist.

The court would decide which one he was.

That wasn't my job anymore.

Mine had ended the moment the handcuffs clicked around his wrists.

. . .

Arjun survived.

Months of therapy followed.

Real therapy.

The kind that helped people live instead of convincing them they couldn't.

The scars on his hand would probably remain forever.

Maybe they should.

Some reminders deserve to stay.

. . .

The families of the three victims finally had answers.

Not all the answers they wanted.

But enough to know they hadn't simply stopped fighting.

Someone had quietly pushed them toward the edge.

That knowledge didn't ease their grief.

Nothing could.

...

The evidence board that had consumed seven days of my life was gone.

The photographs came down.

The reports were boxed away.

Another case replaced it.

Another file.

Another name.

That's how police work goes.

No matter how unforgettable a case feels...

another one is always waiting.

...

A week later, I received a call from ACP Devendra Sinha.

"Coffee?"

I looked at the clock.

"For work?"

He laughed.

"No."

"Just coffee."

...

The café was quieter than I expected.

Mr. Sinha placed a file on the table.

"Thought you'd want this."

I looked at it.

Case Status: Closed

He smiled.

"You earned it."

I flipped through the pages.

Witness statements.

Forensics.

The arrest report.

Everything was there.

Almost everything.

There was one page missing.

"The interrogation transcript."

Mr. Sinha nodded.

"I had it sealed."

"Why?"

He took a sip of his coffee.

"Because some conversations are evidence."

"And some..."

"...are poison."

Kabir looked at him.

"You actually believe words can do that?"

Mr. Sinha didn't answer immediately.

Instead, he looked out the café window.

"I've been doing this for thirty years."

"I've learned not to underestimate what people leave behind."

...

When I reached home that night...

I placed the case file on the top shelf of my bookcase.

I told myself I'd never open it again.

Some stories deserve to stay finished.

I switched off the light.

Closed the door.

And walked away.

Outside, the city carried on as if nothing had happened.

Maybe that's what justice looked like.

Not celebration.

Not revenge.

Just...

another sunrise for the people who were still alive.

...

...